

Wanjiang (Jacob) Zhang

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Research Interests:

Computational Social Science, Computer-Mediated Communication (CMC), Social Time, Technology and Lifestyle

Teaching Interests:

Computational Communication Research Methods, Statistics and Causal Inference, Large Language Models and Human-Computer Interaction, AI Programming and Application Development, AI Agent Development and Applications, Quantitative Research Methods

Work Experience

2026. 07 – present

Research Assistant Professor

Department of Language Science and Technology, The Hong Kong Polytechnic University

2024. 03 – 2026. 06

Postdoctoral Research Fellow

Digital Media Data Initiative (DMDI)

School of Journalism and Communication, The Chinese University of Hong Kong

- Assist faculty members in academic research by providing data collection, analysis, research methodology, and technical support.
- Independently developed and maintained ChatDMDI (<https://chatdmdi.com.cuhk.edu.hk/>), an integrated web platform similar to ChatGPT that allows faculty and students to interact with multiple AI models simultaneously, enhancing research and learning.
- Designed and delivered a series of research methodology training lectures covering Causal Inference, Computational Social Science, Artificial Intelligence, and Large Language Models.
- Invited Guest Speaker for the undergraduate course *Digital Science and Artificial Intelligence in the New Media Era*, School of Journalism and Communication, CUHK; delivered a lecture titled *Trying to Be the Last Human Replaced by AI*.
- Invited Guest Speaker for the undergraduate course *Frontiers of New Media Advertising*, School of Journalism and Communication, Shenzhen University; delivered a lecture titled *Scrolling Xiaohongshu with an AI Summarizer: Everything AI Marketing Accounts Didn't Tell You*.

- Invited Guest Speaker at the Department of Language Science and Technology, PolyU; delivered a lecture titled *AI Agent for Everyone*.

Education

2019. 08 – 2024. 03

Ph.D. in Communication

School of Journalism and Communication

The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong

2016. 09 – 2019. 06

Master of Arts in Communication

School of Journalism and Communication

Wuhan University, Wuhan, China

2012. 09 – 2016. 06

Bachelor of Arts in Journalism

School of Journalism and Communication

Anhui University, Anhui, China

Publications (* indicates corresponding author)

1. Mu, H., Chen, A., **Zhang, W. J.**, Zhang, Q., Zhang, M. M., Lu, S., & Liang, H. (2025). Authenticity perceived, authenticity performed: How inconsistency between self-generated and other-generated location-based information influences user engagement on Weibo. *Telematics and Informatics*, 102, 102310. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tele.2025.102310> (SJR: Q1)
2. **Zhang, W. J.**, Yi, J., & Liang, H. (2023). I cue you liking me: Causal and spillover effects of technological engagement bait. *Computers in Human Behavior*, 148, 107864. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2023.107864> (SJR: Q1)
3. **Zhang, W. J.**, & Yi, J. (2023). Mediated fire and distant suffering: The global spectacle of Australian Bushfires in Nature 2.0. *Environmental Communication*, 17(4), 386–406. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17524032.2023.2195100> (SJR: Q1)
4. Yan, Y., Shi, Y. H., Shu, C., Zhang, J. W., & **Zhang, W. J.** (2023). From grains to a tower: Residents' self-organized actions in the early stage of COVID-19 — An analysis of organizational communication in a Wuhan residential WeChat group. *Journalism & Communication*, 30(6), 67–85. 閔岩、時元皓、舒暢、張婧瑋、張皖疆（2023）。聚沙成塔：新冠疫情早期的居民自組織行動——武漢某小區業主微信群的組織傳播分析。《新聞與傳播研究》，30(6)，67–85。

5. Qu, J. G., Yi, J., **Zhang, W. J.**, & Yang, C. Y. (2023). Silence is golden? Mitigating different types of online firestorms of Fortune 100 corporations on Twitter. *Public Relations Review*, 49(5), 102391. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.pubrev.2023.102391> (SJR: Q1)
6. Yi, J., & **Zhang, W. J.*** (2022). Mapping the global flow of computational communication science scholars. *The Journal of International Communication*, 29(1), 144–171. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13216597.2022.2160780>
7. Yan, Y., & **Zhang, W. J.** (2022). Emotional expressions in the online memory of the “Karamay Fire” on Baidu Tieba (2006–2018). *Journalism Research*, (3), 100–116.
閔岩、張皖疆 (2022)。百度貼吧中「克拉瑪依大火」記憶的情感表達 (2006–2018)。《新聞大學》，(3)，100–116。
8. Cheng, C. Y., **Zhang, W. J.**, & Zhang, Q. (2022). Authority-led conspiracy theories in China during the COVID-19 pandemic: Exploring the thematic features and rhetoric strategies. *Convergence*, 13548565221102592. <https://doi.org/10.1177/13548565221102592> (SJR: Q1)
9. Yi, J., Gina Qu, J., & **Zhang, W. J.** (2022). Depicting the emotion flow: Super-spreaders of emotional messages on Weibo during the COVID-19 pandemic. *Social Media + Society*, 8(1), 20563051221084950. <https://doi.org/10.1177/20563051221084950> (SJR: Q1)
10. Zou, W., **Zhang, W. J.**, & Tang, L. (2021). What do social media influencers say about health? A theory-driven content analysis of top ten health influencers’ posts on Sina Weibo. *Journal of Health Communication*, 26(1), 1–11. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10810730.2020.1865486> (SJR: Q1)
11. Yan, Y., & **Zhang, W. J.** (2020). The duality of memory writing: The change of memory structure regarding the “Karamay Fire” on Baidu Tieba. *Journalism & Communication*, 27(5), 73–93. 閔岩、張皖疆 (2020)。數字化記憶的雙重書寫：百度貼吧中「克拉瑪依大火」的記憶結構之變遷。《新聞與傳播研究》，27(5)，73–93。
12. Yan, Y., & **Zhang, W.** (2020). Gossip at one’s fingertips: Predictors of celebrity news on Twitter. *Journalism*, 21(5), 707–726. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1464884918791349> (SJR: Q1)

Conference Papers

Awarded Papers

1. Qu, J. G., Yi, J., **Zhang, W. J.** & Yang, Y. (2022, May 20-30). *Mitigating different types of corporate online firestorms on Twitter: An empirical study based on Fortune 100 corporations*. [Paper presentation]. The 72nd ICA Conference, Virtual. [Top Three Student Paper, Public Relations Division], Virtual.

2. Cheng, C. Y., **Zhang, W. J.**, & Zhang, Q. (2021, Aug 4-7). *Conspiracy about COVID-19 Pandemic in Contemporary China: What is the Authority's Role on Weibo*. [**First Place in the Markham Student Competition**, International Communication Division]. AEJMC 2021 Conference, Virtual.
3. **Zhang, W. J.** & Yi, J. (2021, May 27-31). *Mediated fire and distant suffering: The global spectacle of Australian bushfires in nature 2.0*. [**Top Student Paper Award**, Environmental Communication Session]. ICA 2021 Conference, Virtual.

Other Conference Papers

1. Mu, H., **Zhang, W. J.**, & Liang, H. (2025, August 7-10). *More User-Centric or Not? The Influence of Social Relationships on Online Discussions*. [Scholar-to-Scholar (Poster) session]. AEJMC 2025 Conference, San Francisco, USA.
2. Mu, H., Chen, A., **Zhang, W. J.**, Zhang, Q., Zhang, M., Lu, S., & Liang, H. (2023, May 25-29). *Authenticity perceived, authenticity performed: How inconsistency in self-presentations influences user engagement*. [Paper presentation]. The 73rd ICA Conference, Toronto, Ontario, Canada.
3. **Zhang, W. J.**, Chen, A., Mu, H., Zhang, Q., Zhang, M., Lu, S., & Liang, H. (2023, May 25-29). *It matters where you are: The effects of social identity salience on group interaction*. [Paper presentation]. The 73rd ICA Conference, Toronto, Ontario, Canada.
4. **Zhang, W. J.**, Yi, J., & Liang, H. (2023, May 25-29). *I cue you liking me: Causal and spillover effects of technological engagement bait*. [Paper presentation]. The 73rd ICA Conference, Toronto, Ontario, Canada.
5. Yi, J., **Zhang, W. J.** & Qu, J. G. (2022, May 20-30). *Female players in Chinese game forum: Stereotype, stigmatization, materialization*. [Paper presentation]. The 72nd ICA Conference, Virtual.
6. **Zhang, W. J.**, Qu, J. G., Yi, J. (2021, Aug 4-7). *Stripped from society abruptly: Effects of physical social isolation on people's emotional expression and well-being*. [Paper presentation]. AEJMC 2021 Conference, Virtual.
7. Yi, J. & **Zhang, W. J.** (2021, May 27-31). *Mapping the global flow of computational communication science scholars*. [Paper presentation]. ICA 2021 Conference, Virtual.
8. Yi, J., Qu, J. & **Zhang, W. J.** (2020, Aug 6-9). *Depicting the mediated emotion flow: The super-spreaders of emotions during COVID-19 on Weibo*. [Paper presentation]. AEJMC 2020 Conference, Virtual.
9. Qu, J. & **Zhang, W. J.** (2020, May 20-27). *The different picture of gender and emotions: A comparative study of the perceived influences of anime on fans between America and China* [Paper presentation]. ICA 2020 Conference, Virtual.
10. Yan, Y. & **Zhang, W.** (2019, May 10-12). *The duality of memory writing: The change of memory structure regarding the "Karamay Fire"* [Paper presentation]. Media China Research Association of Hundreds, Nanjing, China. (in Chinese)

11. Yan, Y. & **Zhang, W. J.** (2018, August 6-9). *Gossip at one's fingertips: Influential factors of celebrity news on Twitter* [Poster presentation]. AEJMC 2018 Conference, Washington, DC, USA

Ongoing Research Projects

1. **Zhang, W. J.**, Chen, A., Mu, H., Zhang, Q., Zhang, M. M., Lu, S., & Liang, H. It Matters Where You Are: Geolocation-based Social Identity Salience Polarizes Group Interactions on Social Media Platforms. (Currently under review at the *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication*)
2. Chu, D. & **Zhang, W.J.** Unpacking “media literacy” in the digital era: A computational analysis of academic and journalistic discourses. (first-round revision at *Digital Journalism*)
3. Kim, S., & **Zhang, W. J.** *When AI Meets Corporate Social Responsibility: A Comparative Study of AI-related Content on Chinese and Korean Companies' Facebook Accounts.*
4. Koo, A. Z. X. & **Zhang, W.J.** *The Impact of Meme Usage in Images on Political Participation in Hong Kong's Facebook News Accounts: A Multimodal Analysis Using Large Language Models.*

Teaching Experience

2021 – 2022 (Semester 1) | Teaching Assistant

Undergraduate Course: Development of Mass Communication

School of Journalism and Communication, The Chinese University of Hong Kong

Hong Kong SAR, China

- Assisted in course instruction; received “**Best Teaching Assistant Award.**”
- Conducted tutorials and evaluated students' performance and assignments.

2021 – 2022 (Semester 1) | Research Assistant

School of Journalism and Communication, The Chinese University of Hong Kong

Hong Kong SAR, China

- Assisted professors in conducting research projects.
- Awarded “**Best Research Assistant Award.**”

2020 – 2021 (Semester 2) | Teaching Assistant

Undergraduate Course: Introduction to Global Communication

School of Journalism and Communication, The Chinese University of Hong Kong
Hong Kong SAR, China

- Assisted in course instruction; received “**Best Teaching Assistant Award.**”
- Conducted tutorials, provided feedback, and graded student assignments.

2020 – 2021 (Semester 1) | Teaching Assistant

Undergraduate Course: Development of Mass Communication

School of Journalism and Communication, The Chinese University of Hong Kong
Hong Kong SAR, China

- Assisted in course instruction; received “**Best Teaching Assistant Award.**”
- Conducted tutorials and provided guidance on students’ term papers.

Skills and Research Methods

Programming and Technical Skills

- Proficient in **Python** and **R** programming languages.
- Experienced in developing AI applications, AI agent, web systems, and mini-programs.
- Experienced in fine-tuning and applying AI image and video generation models.

Research Methods

- **Data Collection:** Skilled in Python-based web scraping, with extensive experience gathering data from various websites and social media platforms.
- **Data Analysis:** Proficient in computational social science methods, including Structural Topic Models (STM), social network analysis, and large language model (LLM)–based content analysis; experienced with causal inference techniques for observational data, such as Difference-in-Differences (DiD), matching, and multilevel regression models, generative-AI powered (GPI) causal inference; familiar with survey and experimental quantitative methods.
- **Data Visualization:** Skilled at creating visualizations using Python and R plotting libraries, as well as social network visualization tools like Gephi.